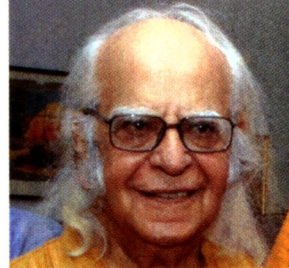


YASH PAL *Former Chairman, University Grants Commission*



Expansion with Access

We need more universities, upgradation of colleges and reinvention of IITs

You can have all the knowledge, but you need different contexts in which to use that knowledge. A good university provides that. It isn't a factory that creates the same kind of students by giving them the same kind of instruction. Though everyone doesn't have to go to a university, there's still no better place to be than at a good one. To meet professors and see them as human beings is very different from what you think of them when you read their books and papers. You attain education through teachers and not because of what you learn from those teachers. You get education from watching those teachers teach in the class-

SUVASHIS MULLICK



REMOVING RESTRICTIONS ON DISCIPLINES WILL HELP BUILD NEW KNOWLEDGE

rooms, fumbling sometimes, thinking and trying to find words. You can see their thoughts as they are happening. But in our country less than ten per cent go to college while in other countries it is between 20 to 40 per cent. It is not fair to deny those who want to study further. Higher education may be good for economics but it is also the cherished goal of human beings. We definitely need more universities in the country.

► We can convert some of our large colleges, those that have 5,000 to 6,000 students, into universities by giving them autonomy and power.

Choosing 1,000-1,500 colleges can do this. These are universities that know how to work as institutions. They should be told it is time to grow up.

► There should be an attempt to create new knowledge at universities by getting senior professors to interact with younger students in colleges. They should be given dual appointments in the college and university. Over the last 10 to 15 years, all I have learnt is because children have asked questions. We need to create this kind of a culture in our universities.

► Let the IITs teach more subjects. They have limited themselves to only teaching engineering and a few other areas. So they tend to acquire a character of an efficient undergraduate factory. Education is not just undergraduate engineering. One of the greatest tragedies of recent times has been that many young people get a job before they finish their undergraduate studies. These are bright people who are capable of thinking much deeper thoughts and can help create new knowledge.

► Also, universities shouldn't be restricted by disciplines. At a place like the Massachusetts Institute of Technology, a large number of people from different fields are working on sky art—a combination of visual art and architecture. We met many people from the IIT management and proposed this idea. They thought it was a great idea and some are actually trying to do something of this sort. But such an effort should be legalised and not done in a subversive manner.

► All this requires a change in our way of thinking. There are brilliant people everywhere. Their brilliance lies in different fields but there isn't enough freedom given. We went to the Jadavpur University in Kolkata where we talked about having IITs with courses in humanities and economics. Then I got a letter from one of the professors who said there was once a proposal to recognise the university as an IIT. A team went to see if it qualified, but it didn't. When the management asked for a reason, it was told that even though the university was great in engineering, it taught other subjects as well—philosophy, psychology and literature. How could the university then qualify as an IIT? Now that is exactly the thinking we need to abolish. *As told to Chitra Subramanyam*

1,60,000

Indian students go abroad for education, spending \$4 billion annually.